

Graffiti art

By creating art on the streets, artists can communicate directly with the public away from museums and galleries. The word 'graffiti' comes from the Italian *graffiato* meaning 'scratched', and the earliest examples were carved on walls with sharp objects, such as in the Roman and Pompeian catacombs. The Mayan site of Tikal in Guatemala also contains ancient examples.

Graffiti art flourished in 1970s New York, notably with artists such as Jean-Michel Basquiat (1960–88) and Keith Haring (1958–90). Basquiat achieved notoriety as part of SAMO, an informal graffiti group based in Manhattan's Lower East Side, while Haring, inspired by Dubuffet and Warhol, also became involved with the New York street culture of the 1980s. Lee Quiñones (b.1960) was part of a Subway graffiti movement entrenched in popular culture, frequently using political messages. The elusive British graffiti artist Banksy creates realistic satirical images of political and social commentary on pavements, walls and bridges in cities around the world.



Basquiat, *Untitled*, 1981